Despite the rivalries and clashes among these competing branches of the Mongol family, their rule over a vast expanse of Eurasia created avenues of safe travel and trade between Asia and Europe. Missionaries and traders alike made the long journey between China and the Mediterranean, exchanging not only a wide variety of goods but also knowledge and cultural practices. Demand for spices, in particular pepper, saw a quantum increase in European markets. The account of the travels of Marco Polo, the Italian merchant, reflect the burgeoning mutual curiosity between East and West. This may well have inspired the voyages across the seas to find a more direct route to the Indies. Christopher Columbus is said to have carried a copy of Marco Polo's travelogue with him when he set out to find a sea route to India.

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Kublai Khan initially ruled from his capital at Khara Khorum (also spelt as Karakoram) in Mongolia, but then later shifted his capital to Dadu, the 'Big City', present-day Beijing. He distrusted the scholar-official class, the 'Mandarins' (derived from the Sanskrit word 'mantrin' meaning minister or counsellor), who constituted the bureaucracy at various levels of administration and who considered themselves the upholders of China's traditional culture and the Confucian code of ethics. Even during the rule of non-Han dynasties, they constituted an educated and influential elite. Kublai Khan preferred to rule through a number of Muslim officials he inducted into his administration. He abolished the civil service examinations constituted under the earlier Sui dynasty (581–618 CE). But these exams were continued under subsequent dynasties and were the main source of an educated elite which manned the administration at all levels. This is also the time that we first hear of the influence exercised by Tibetan lamas, who enjoyed high respect at the Mongol court. For example, a new legal code and a new script were the contributions of the Tibetan lama, Phags-pa. Phags-pa developed the theory of the separation of the state from religion. The concept of a patron–priest relationship was his contribution. The Yuan emperor Kublai Khan also commissioned Phags-pa to design a